City of Victoria Falls

RAMSAR WETLAND ACCREDITATION



What is a Wetland?



• Wetlands are ecosystems where land and water meet, creating unique environments that support diverse plant and animal life.

• They are characterized by saturated soil, waterlogged conditions, and specific vegetation adapted to wet conditions.

Examples of wetlands:

- **Swamps:** forested wetlands often found in low-lying areas.
- **Marshes:** grass-dominated wetlands that are periodically flooded.
- **Peatlands:** wetlands that accumulate peat, a type of soil rich in organic material.
- **Mangroves:** coastal wetlands found in tropical regions, known for their salt-tolerant trees.

Value of wetlands:

- Wetlands are crucial for biodiversity, housing about 40% of the world's plant and animal species, including many endangered species.

Statistics:

- Approximately 35% of wetlands have disappeared since 1970, with a loss rate three times faster than that of forests.

Consequences of wetland loss:

- This rapid decline threatens global biodiversity, compromises water quality, destabilizes climate, and jeopardizes the livelihoods of millions who rely on wetland resources.





Role of United Nations



The UN’s Role in Wetland Conservation:

- The UN plays a pivotal role in advocating for wetland conservation through the Ramsar Convention, an international treaty focused on the sustainable management of wetlands.
- The treaty has been signed by over 170 countries, emphasizing the global commitment to wetland protection.

World Wetlands Day:

- Celebrated annually on February 2nd, this day raises awareness about wetland conservation and promotes actions to protect these vital ecosystems.

Support Provided by the UN:

- The UN offers scientific guidance, policy support, and funding to assist countries in protecting, restoring, and sustainably managing their wetlands as part of broader development plans.

SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOALS (SDGS)

Importance of Wetlands for SDGs:

Wetlands play a crucial role in achieving the following goals:

SDG 6 (Clean Water and Sanitation):

- Wetlands filter pollutants and ensure clean water availability for both people and ecosystems.

SDG 13 (Climate Action):

- They act as carbon sinks, helping communities adapt to climate change impacts.

SDG 14 (Life Below Water):

- Wetlands support healthy aquatic ecosystems, benefiting fisheries and biodiversity.

SDG 15 (Life on Land):

- Protecting wetlands is essential for maintaining biodiversity and ecosystem health.

SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production):

- Sustainable management of wetlands supports responsible resource use.

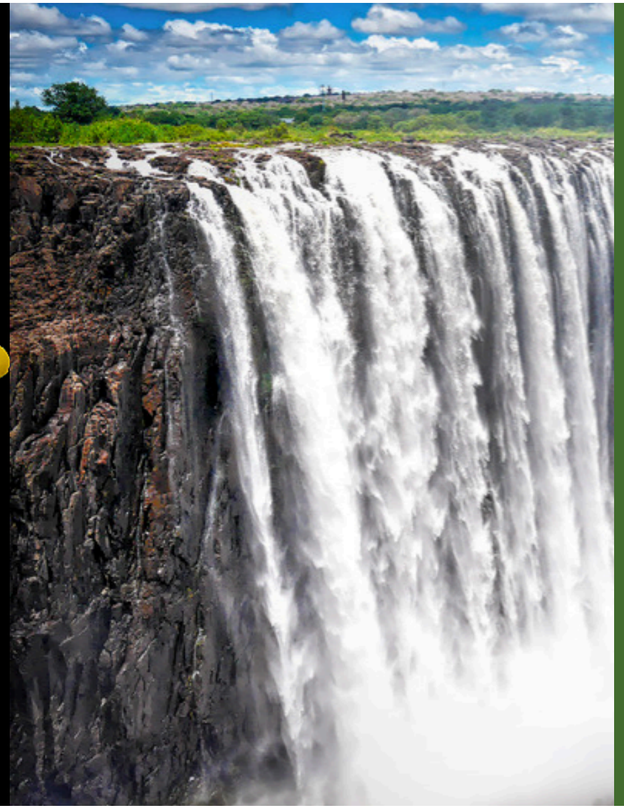
AFRICAN UNION – AGENDA 2063 GOAL 7

- The African Union’s Agenda 2063 aims for a prosperous and united Africa, emphasizing sustainability.



Goal 7:
This goal focuses on ensuring environmental sustainability and promoting the sustainable use of natural resources across the continent





ZIMBABWE LEGAL FRAMEWORK

Supreme Law of the Land:

- Section 73 of the Constitution: Guarantees the right to a clean and healthy environment for all citizens.

Environmental Management Agency (EMA):
The EMA is mandated to protect and manage Zimbabwe's natural resources, including wetlands, through effective policies and regulations.

NDS1 Policies:
The National Development Strategy 1 emphasizes sustainable management of natural resources and promotes wetland conservation as part of national development goals.

City of Victoria Falls' Journey to Accreditation

- The City of Victoria Falls is recognized as a Ramsar Wetland City,reflecting its commitment to wetland conservation.

Enabling Policies:

- Local regulations have been put in place to protect wetlands and ensure sustainable use of these ecosystems.

COMMUNITY PARTICIPATION



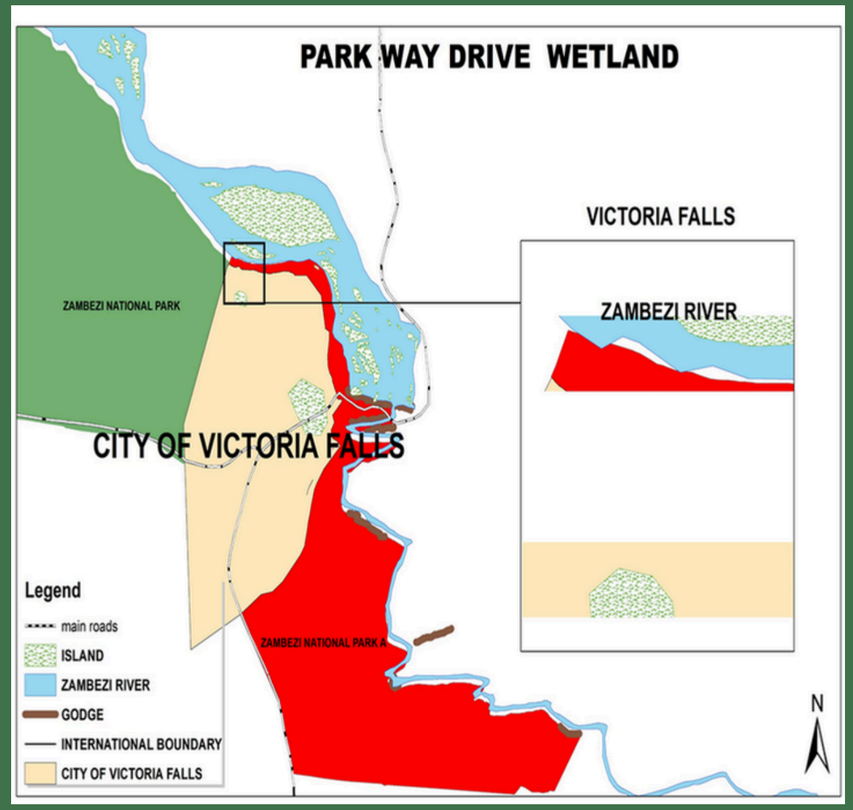
- Active involvement of local communities in conservation efforts plays a critical role in preserving wetland ecosystems.
- Educational campaigns aim to raise awareness about the importance of wetlands and encourage responsible practices.
- Collaborations with organizations like the Environmental Management Agency (EMA), the Victoria Falls Pristine Society, and others have been instrumental in implementing wetland conservation initiatives, waste management, and community engagement.

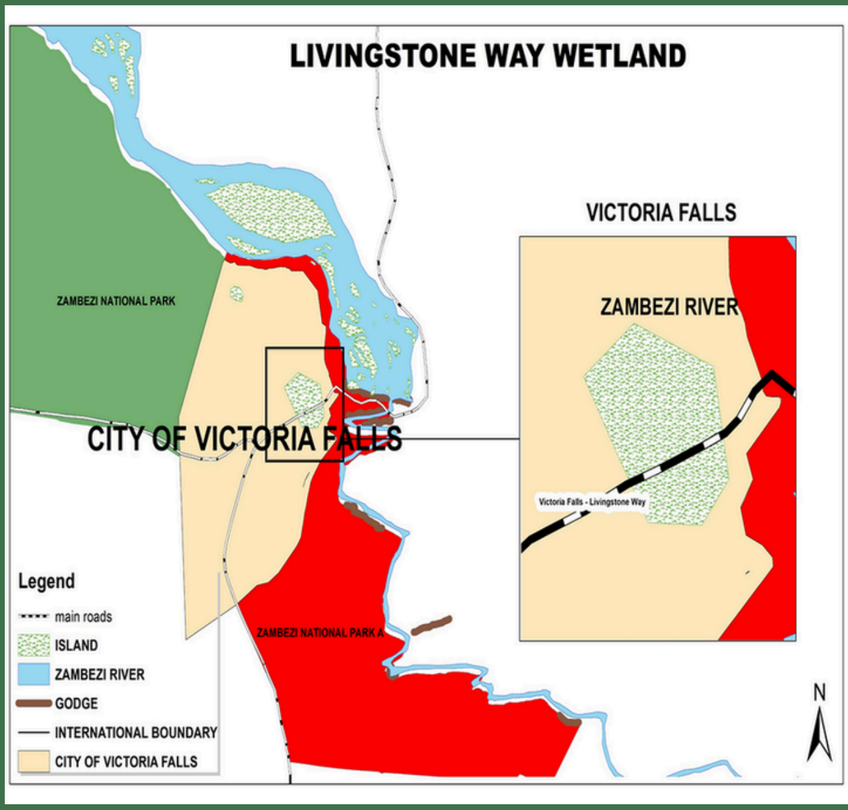
EDUCATION AND INVOLVEMENT OF SCHOOL CHILDREN



By integrating wetland education into school programs and encouraging active participation,
Victoria Falls and Zimbabwe are investing in a future where wetlands continue to provide vital services and benefits for all.
This approach not only protects the environment but also empowers young people to become leaders in conservation and sustainable development.

The city has already identified and is preserving five specific wetland areas: Victoria Falls National Park, the vlei behind Ilala Lodge, the municipal water-treatment swamp, the dam behind Shearwater Village, and the seasonal Chamabondo Vlei.

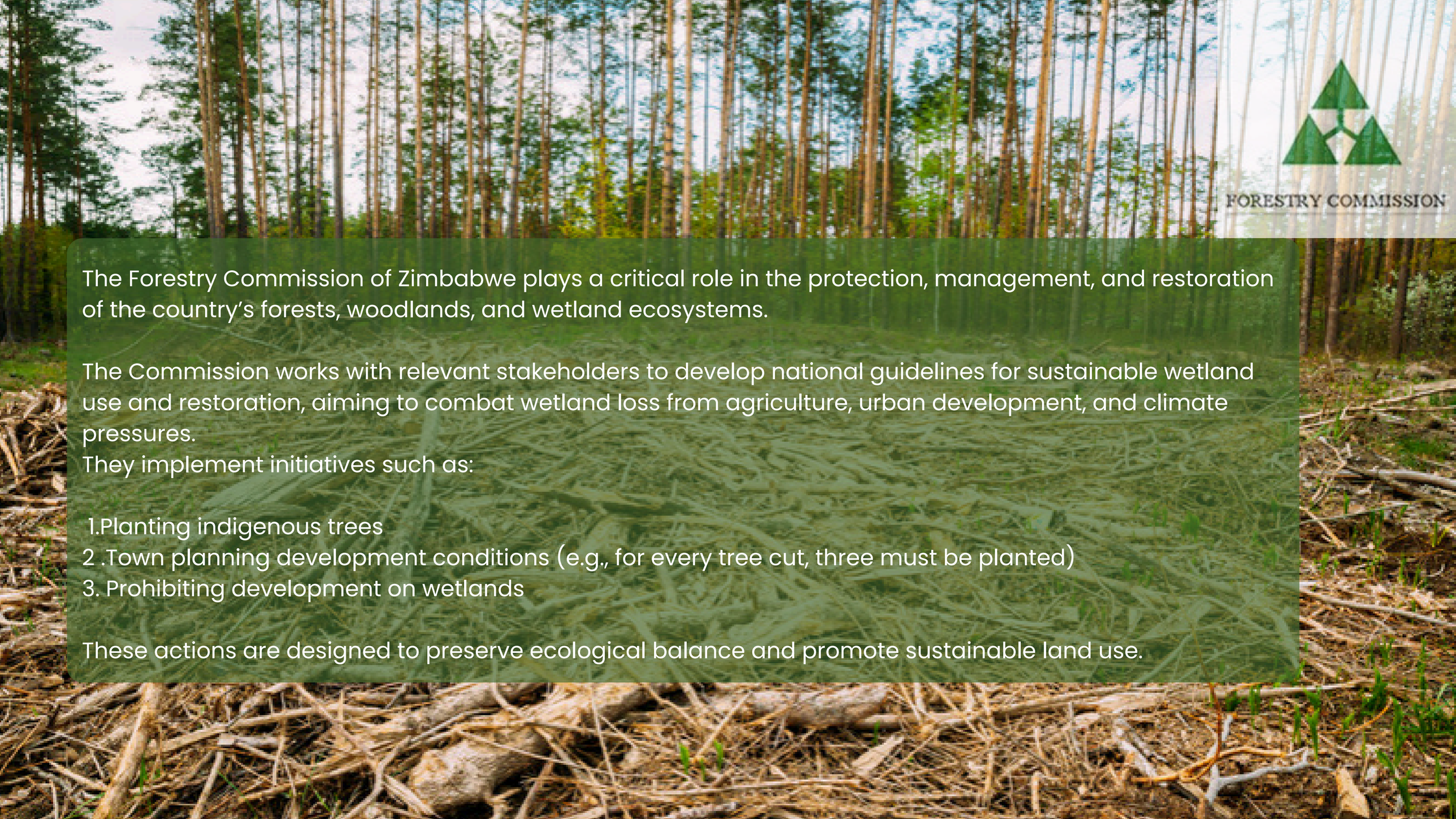






Role of Partners

- The Zimbabwe Parks and Wildlife Management Authority (ZimParks) is responsible for managing several Ramsar-designated wetlands and national parks, including Victoria Falls National Park, Mana Pools, and Chinhoyi Caves.
- Through the JIPM (Joint Integrated Management Plan) Committee, as well as joint site management committees of the two states—Zambia and Zimbabwe—conservation reports are developed to guide initiatives.
- These include development controls to protect these wetlands, along with other conservation initiatives.



The Forestry Commission of Zimbabwe plays a critical role in the protection, management, and restoration of the country's forests, woodlands, and wetland ecosystems.

The Commission works with relevant stakeholders to develop national guidelines for sustainable wetland use and restoration, aiming to combat wetland loss from agriculture, urban development, and climate pressures.
They implement initiatives such as:

1.Planting indigenous trees
2 .Town planning development conditions (e.g., for every tree cut, three must be planted)
3. Prohibiting development on wetlands

These actions are designed to preserve ecological balance and promote sustainable land use.

Ele-Collection

is a vital partner in Victoria Falls' mission to protect its wetlands and natural environment by tackling plastic pollution at its source.









Recycling

- Youth from the city collect plastic and tin waste from the dumpsite and turn it into crafts, helping protect wetlands by reducing pollution.
- Their creative recycling efforts prevent harmful materials from reaching these delicate ecosystems, raising awareness about environmental conservation while promoting sustainability through art.





Waste Management and Clean-Up Campaigns:

- Local residents participate in regular clean-ups and support enforcement of littering and dumping laws, improving wetland and urban environments.







The City of Victoria Falls has collaborated with government agencies and NGO’s to run awareness campaigns, workshops, and school programs that promote wetland conservation.







In Conclusion

Wetlands are essential ecosystems that support biodiversity, regulate climate, and provide vital services to communities. Despite facing significant threats and rapid loss, global initiatives like the Ramsar Convention highlight the need for urgent action.

The City of Victoria Falls shows how effective policies and community involvement can successfully protect wetlands.

By prioritizing their conservation, we can ensure these ecosystems continue to benefit future generations and promote sustainable development.

Thank You

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